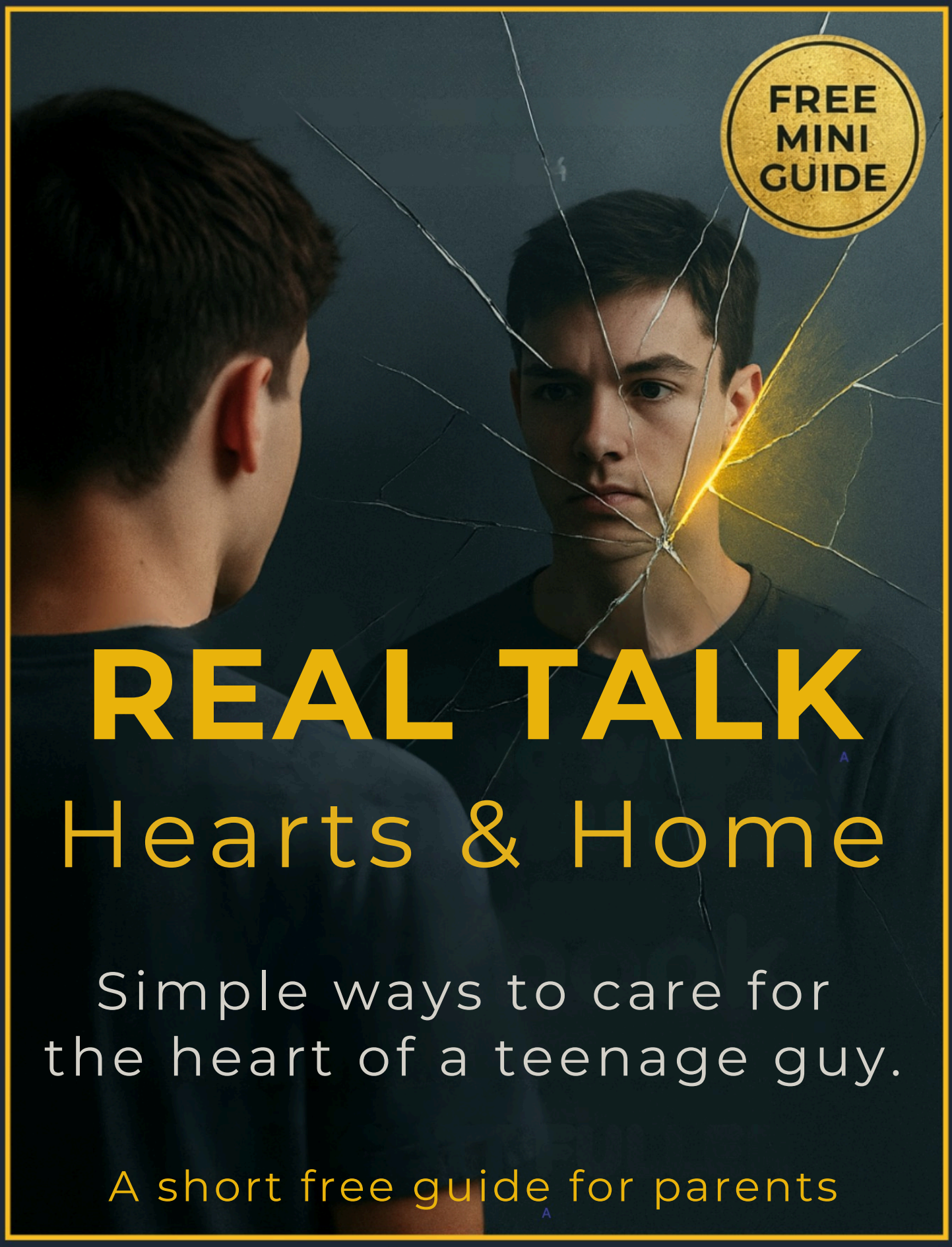


REAL TALK

Hearts & Home

Simple ways to care for
the heart of a teenage guy.

A short free guide for parents

Real Talk Hearts & Home

Simple ways to care for the heart of a teenage guy.

Introduction – When His World Gets Quiet

If you're reading this, there's probably a guy in your life you care about more than he will ever fully know.

Maybe he used to talk your ear off, and now you're lucky to get a shrug.
Maybe family dinners have turned into one-word answers and a glowing screen.
Maybe you've seen flashes of anger, silence, or shut-down and thought, *"Where did my kid go?"*

You might also be noticing new questions rising to the surface:

- About faith: *Does he believe this for himself—or just because we do?*
- About identity: *Does he know who he is beyond grades, sports, or mistakes?*
- About emotions: *Is he okay? And would he even tell me if he wasn't?*

If you've ever lain awake at night replaying a conversation and wishing you could redo it—
If you've wondered whether you're saying too much or not enough—
If you've felt the quiet fear of, *"I don't want to lose him, but I don't always know how to reach him"...*

You are not failing.
You are not alone.
And you are not behind.

Teenage guys often pull back, get quieter, and protect their inner world more closely. It's a normal part of growing up, but it can make home feel tense, confusing, or fragile. The good news: God has not stepped back from your son. He sees every thought, every fear, every hope he doesn't have words for yet. (See Psalm 139:1–4.)

This guide is not about perfect speeches or dramatic "heart-to-hearts."
It's about something quieter—and honestly, more powerful:

Small, steady, heart-level moments at home that say:
"You matter. You are seen. Your heart is safe with me."

In the next few pages, you'll find a handful of simple practices. They're designed for real life: busy evenings, long car rides, homework at the table, and the in-between spaces where a boy's heart often peeks out for just a second.

Take what fits. Adapt what doesn't.
There is no rush, no timeline, and no grade.

You're here. You care.
That already matters more than you know.

Hearts & Home Practices

Practice 1: Quiet Car Moments

For many teen guys, the car is one of the safest places to talk. No direct eye contact. No pressure. Just the hum of the road and a little bit of shared space.

Instead of using every drive to lecture or "catch up," what if you treated some car rides as quiet invitations?

Think of these moments as gentle open doors, not forced conversations. Some days he'll walk through. Some days he won't. Both are okay.

This Week: Try This

Pick one short drive—practice, school, church, or a store run.
Before you start the car, take a breath and decide: "This ride is for small connections, not big talks."

- Turn down the music just a little.
- Start with something light and specific, not "How was your day?"
- If he answers with one word, don't panic. Thank him for the answer and move on.

Your job is to make the car feel like a calm place, not an interrogation room.

Conversation Starters

"What was one not-terrible part of today?"

"If today had a soundtrack, what song would be on it?"

"Did anything surprise you today—in a good or weird way?"

"On a scale of 1–10, how tired are you?"

"Anything you're looking forward to this week, even a little bit?"

Practice 2: One Honest Question

Teen guys can feel surrounded by expectations—be strong, be funny, be chill, be fine. Underneath all of that, many of them are quietly wondering:

"Is it okay to say what I really feel?"

One way to care for his heart is to offer one honest question at a time—and then treat his answer with respect, even if it's not what you hoped to hear.

The power isn't in the perfect wording.
The power is in the safety you create when you ask and then really listen.

This Week: Try This

Choose one moment—maybe after dinner, a walk, or while you're both doing something side by side (dishes, folding laundry, shooting hoops).

Ask a single honest question like, “How’s your heart these days?” or “What’s been heavy for you lately?”

Then:

Don’t rush to fix.

Don’t jump in with a story of your own.

Don’t turn it into a full-blown lecture.

You might simply respond with:

> “Thank you for telling me that.”
>
> “That makes sense.”
>
> “I’m really glad you trusted me with that.”

Conversation Starters

> “On the inside, are you more tired, stressed, or okay lately?”
>
> “What’s one thing you wish adults understood about being your age right now?”
>
> “If you could change one thing about school/friends right now, what would it be?”
>
> “Where do you feel the most like yourself?”
>
> “Are there any questions about faith or God you don’t feel like you can ask out loud?”

Practice 3: Safe Places to Feel

A lot of guys have learned—directly or indirectly—that big feelings are "too much" or "not manly." So they shut down, joke it off, or push their emotions into anger because that feels safer.

Home can become a different kind of place.

You can't shield him from every hard thing.
But you can build a home where it's okay to feel what he feels and still belong.

That doesn't mean there are no boundaries. It does mean that fear, sadness, confusion, and even doubt are welcomed, not punished.

This Week: Try This

Look for one moment when your son's emotions peek through—maybe in his tone, his posture, or a comment he tosses out.

Instead of correcting the emotion ("Don't be dramatic," "You're fine"), try naming it gently:

> "That sounds really disappointing."
>
> "It seems like that made you angry."
>
> "I can tell that hurt your feelings."

Then add a simple reassurance:

> "I'm here with you in this."
>
> "It's okay to feel that way."
>
> "You don't have to have it all figured out."

You're not giving him permission to be hurtful; you're giving him permission to be human.

Conversation Starters

"What's been most frustrating lately?"

"When you're stressed, what helps you the most—space, talking, music, something else?"

"Is it easier for you to show you're upset through anger, jokes, or silence?"

"When was the last time you felt really proud of yourself?"

"If your emotions were a weather report this week, what would it be?"

Practice 4: Name the Good You See

Teen guys hear a lot about what they're doing wrong: grades, chores, attitude, screens. Even necessary corrections can pile up until they quietly believe, "I am mostly a problem to be fixed."

One of the simplest ways to care for his heart is to name the good you see in him—specifically, and not only when he performs well.

This isn't fake praise or pretending everything is fine. It's paying attention to where God's fingerprints are already visible in his life and saying it out loud.

"We are God's masterpiece..." (Ephesians 2:10)
Your son is not a project. He is a person God is shaping.

This Week: Try This

Over the next few days, look for one small moment that reflects his character:

He helped a sibling without being asked.

He showed up even though he didn't want to.

He kept going when something was hard.

He made someone laugh at just the right time.

Then, within 24 hours, tell him what you noticed.

Keep it short and calm:

> "I saw how patient you were with your brother earlier. That was really kind."
>
> "You could've quit, but you didn't. That shows a lot of strength."
>
> "You have a quiet way of making people feel included. That's a gift."

Let it land and don't follow it with a correction in the same breath.

Conversation Starters

> "What's something about yourself you actually like?"
>
> "If your best friend had to describe you in three words, what do you think they'd say?"
>
> "What's one way you've grown in the past year, even if it's small?"
>
> "If God sees you as His masterpiece, what part of you do you hope He's especially proud of?"
>
> "What do you wish adults would notice and appreciate more about you?"

Reflection & Conversation Prompts (Quick-Glance Page)

You can use these as personal reflection prompts, as conversation starters with your son, or both. There's no "right" way—these are tools to help you notice, listen, and love with intention.

Where do I see my son most relaxed and most himself?

When was the last time I simply enjoyed being with him, without correcting or critiquing?

In what situations do I tend to lecture instead of listen?

What do I most want my son to know about God's heart for him? Have I said it out loud?

What fears about his future might be shaping the way I talk to him now?

Questions you can ask your teen (over time, not all at once):

"What helps you feel respected by adults?"

"Is there anything I do that makes it harder for you to be honest with me?"

"When life feels heavy, who do you feel safest talking to?"

"If you could design a 'perfect evening' at home, what would it look like?"

"Are there any rules or expectations that don't make sense to you? Can we talk about them?"

More heart-level prompts for you:

One way I see God at work in my son right now is...

A strength in his character that I might be overlooking is...

One small change I can make this week to create more calm at home is...

A phrase of grace I want to say more often (to him and to myself) is...

I want our home to be a place where it's safe to _____ and _____.

You don't need to journal page after page. Even sitting with one question and a cup of coffee can slowly recenter your heart toward connection rather than control.

Closing – Gentle Next Steps

If you've made it this far, pause and hear this:

You are showing up.
You are paying attention.
You care about your son's heart—not just his behavior.

That matters.

You won't get this right every day. None of us do. There will still be eye rolls, slammed doors, awkward silences, and conversations you wish had gone differently. But every small moment of presence—every car ride, every honest question, every quiet blessing you speak over him—is planting something deeper than you can see.

God is not asking you to create a perfect teenager.
He is inviting you to walk with the one you have, right here, right now.

If You'd Like to Go Deeper...

This mini guide is meant to be a gentle starting point. If you're ready for more support and structure, the Real Talk series is here to walk alongside you and your son.

Real Talk: Becoming Who God Made You to Be (Student Book)
A faith-based, honest book written directly to teen guys. It helps them wrestle with identity, emotions, friendships, and faith in real life—without cheesy clichés or pressure to pretend.

Real Talk Workbook (Companion for Teen Guys)
A simple, practical workbook that pairs with the student book. It gives teen guys space to respond, reflect, and apply the ideas in their own words, at their own pace.

Real Talk Parent Guide
A parent companion that helps you track what your son is reading, ask better questions, and create meaningful conversations at home—without turning every chapter into a lecture.

You can explore all of these resources at www.ivoryroad.shop—just look for the Real Talk collection. From there, you'll also find links to order the student book and guides on Amazon if that's easier for you.

These resources are not "fixes" for your son.

They're tools to help both of you move toward each other, and toward the young man God is shaping him to be.

Wherever you are starting today is enough.
You don't have to do this alone.